



May following a landslide victory in the Assembly elections, the party had little to celebrate as it completed its first year in office. Then two things made the Government's fortunes soar: Mission Munnar, a massive demolition drive against unauthorised structures in the picturesque Hill Ranges in Central Kerala, and the signing of the Rs 1,500-crore Smart City project. These helped the Government garner such unprecedented support that even the usually combative Opposition doffed its hat in appreciation. As the media portrayed the 84-year-old chief minister as the new cult hero, Vijayan, 63, took umbrage at Achuthanandan hogging all the credit alone.

This was only the latest in a long drawn-out battle between the two (see box). All along, the politburo had stood by helplessly as the Kerala veterans slugged it out. But finally it acted. "Such behaviour violates party discipline and is unacceptable from members of the politburo," said Prakash Karat, CPI(M) general secretary. "The 80-member central committee would determine the period of suspension." Achuthanandan and Vijayan, both from the OBC Ezhava community, had climbed up the party ladder the hard way, a fact that is not lost on the CPI(M) central leadership, some of whom were drafted straight from Leftist bastion campuses into the politburo.

Ironically, the two warring comrades had been thick as thieves until about two decades ago. But while Achuthanandan enjoys mass support, his hold on the organisation is somewhat suspect. Vijayan has an iron grip over the state party unit but his public

## BLOW BY BLOW

- CPI(M) state leadership denies Achuthanandan a ticket in the May 2006 Assembly polls. Politburo intervenes, names him as chief ministerial candidate.
- State secretariat and committee dominated by Vijayan faction crowd ministry with campers.
- Achuthanandan denied Home portfolio.
- Vijayan faction appoints its nominee as LDF convenor.
- Vijayan faction nominees get all the important posts in the Government and the party.
- Disciplinary action against Achuthanandan campers, including MPs and ministers.
- Most district committees and feeder organisations captured by official faction.

image is not the kind that can improve electoral prospects. The two have often clashed in the past. A decade ago, the politburo had tacitly admitted that factionalism in the state unit was getting out of hand, but it did little to rein in the indiscipline, mainly due to the erosion of its moral and political authority. "The centre cannot hold anymore as is seen in all political organisations. In the CPI(M), there's been a steady erosion in the leadership's moral and political authority," says a senior party member. The politburo was once dominated by veterans like E.M.S. Namboodiripad, Jyoti Basu

## MAKEOVER: The Smart City project (left) and the demolition drive triggered the latest intra-party conflict

and P. Sundarayya, whose records of struggles, service and ideology remain unmatched. "How can a Prakash Karat or Sitaram Yechury lecture Achuthanandan, who participated in the legendary Punnappa-Vayalar revolt when they were not even born?" asks a party veteran.

Although the party has asked both the warring leaders to continue in their posts, the Opposition UDF feels this is not done. "A chief minister who does not enjoy the trust of the party has no right to remain in power. The punishment has affected the administration in the state. Bureaucracy has started ignoring his orders," says former chief minister Oommen Chandy. However, Congress leader and Union Minister for Overseas Indian Affairs Vayalar Ravi says the disciplinary action in the CPI(M) is a lesson for other parties too.

Although the politburo action was welcomed by the state party and the public, not all agreed. An independent newspaper, *Kerala Kaumudi*, said in an editorial: "PB's was an over-reaction to relatively mild violations of its dictates by the two leaders. The same politburo should have had the guts to initiate action against Jyoti Basu when he dubbed its decision not to field him as a prime ministerial candidate, a historic blunder." Watching from the sidelines with glee is the Congress-led UDF. In the state's revolving door policy of governance, it's their turn next to rule. With their antics, the Leftists are making the UDF's job of regaining power just that much easier.